1.5 'DOVER BEACH'

'Dover Beach' is one of the most admired of Arnold's poems today. The sea features in this poem and you will notice that the sea is a recurring feature in most English literature. As we know that as England is an island, the sea is never far away. This is very similar to the heat and dust that is often featured in Indian literature. But the sea can mean different things to different poets and writers. For Byron, in his poem 'Ocean', the sea is an angry potent force that punishes man for his pettiness. The sea can be bountiful; it can be benevolent as it brings 'the sailor home from the sea'. Or it can separate lovers as it does in the context of 'To Marguerite'. Let us now see, how the sea is handled in 'Dover Beach'.

'Dover Beach', though written much earlier, was only published in 1857 in *New Poems*. In fact a manuscript of part of 'Dover Beach' dates back to June 1851 when Arnold went on his honeymoon with his wife Lucy. Nature is at its best as Lucy and Arnold look at the moon and the calm sea, and on this clear night can see the light on the French coast. Yet this perfect setting does not evoke any romantic feelings in the poet. On the other hand, the mood is one of melancholy and nostalgia for the loss of faith. Once again Arnold outlines the human condition and feels that love alone can somewhat lessen the pain of isolation and suffering. One of Arnold's most celebrated lyrics, the tone of this poem is almost conversational.

1.5.1 Poem

DOVER BEACH

The sea is calm to-night.
The tide is full, the moon lies fair
Upon the **straits**;—on the French coast the light
Gleams and is gone; the cliffs of England stand,
Glimmering and vast, out in the **tranquil bay.**
Come to the window, **sweet** is the night-air!
Only, from the **long line of spray**
Where the sea meets the **moon-blanch'd land,**
Listen! you hear the **grating roar**
Of pebbles which the waves draw back, and fling,
At their return, up the **high, strand**,
Begin, and cease, and then again begin,
With **tremulous cadence** slow, and bring
The eternal note of sadness in. 14
Sophocles long ago
Heard it on the **Aegean**, and it brought
Into his mind the **turbid** ebb and flow
Of human misery; we
Find also in the sound a thought,
Hearing it by this **distant northern sea.**
The Sea of Faith 21

BEGC-110_3rd Proof.indb 187 6/21/2021 11:41:05 AM

Was once, too, at the full, and round earth's shore
Lay like the folds of a bright **girdle furl'd;**
But now I only hear
Its melancholy, long, withdrawing roar,
Retreating, to the breath
Of the night-wind, down the vast edges **drear**
naked shingles of the world.
Ah, **love**, let us be true
To one another! for the world, which seems
To lie before us like a land of dreams,
So various, so beautiful, so new,
Hath really neither joy, nor love, nor light,
Nor **certitude**, nor peace, nor help for pain:
And we are here as on a **darkling** plain
Swept with confused alarms of struggle and flight.
Where **ignorant armies clash by night**.

1.5.2 Glossary

straits : the English Channel separating France and England.

gleams : Shines

tranquil bay : calm sea enclosed by the wide curve of the shore

sweet : pleasant

long line of spray : beach, where water hits the land.

moon-blanched : lit up by the moon

grating roar : harsh sound caused by the pebbles being moved by the incoming and receding waves.

high strand : high beach

tremulous cadence : trembling wavering rhythm.

Sophocles (Circa 496-406 B.C.) : In *Antigone* the Greek dramatist likens the curse of heaven to the ebb and flow of the sea. Sophocles is famous for the great tragedies *Antigone, Oedipus*, *Electra* among others.

Aegean : The part of the Mediterranean sea near Greece, where Aegeus jumped in and committed suicide, is called the Aegean.

turbid : muddy (unclear) tide

distant northern sea : the English Channel which is to the north of the Mediterranean.

sea of Faith : faith in religion

girdle : belt, but here–bright clothing

furl'd : folded/compressed/at ebb tide, as the sea retreats, it is unfurled and spread out

drear : dull

shingles : small pebbles on the shore

naked shingles : gravel beaches

BEGC-110_3rd Proof.indb 188 6/21/2021 11:41:05 AM

love	:	refers to Lucy
certitude	:	certainty
darkling	:	darkened
ignorant armies clash by night	:	the image of a battle by night, when both friend and foe are confused in the darkness and it is not clear who is fighting whom and for what

1.5.3 Discussion: Paraphrase and Style

'Dover Beach' is a short poem, but it embraces a great range and depth of significance. What is Arnold's main pre-occupation in this poem? He ruminates on the loss of religious faith and the subsequent vulnerability of human beings to the sufferings and pains of life. It is only through a satisfying love-relationship that one can wrest a meaningful existence in an otherwise meaningless and hostile universe.

As you already know, Arnold spent a night in Dover while on his honeymoon trip with Lucy. Here he is standing at the window with Lucy by his side on an exceptionally clear night looking at the sea. Not only is it clear but Arnold's opening lines suggest a calm and stability: a kind of poise that Arnold probably desires for himself.

Paraphrase

Arnold observes that the sea is calm, the tide is high and the moon is shining on the English Channel. On the distant French coast he can see a slight flicker of light which shines briefly and then disappears. The white cliffs of Dover can be seen large and shining in the curve of the shore. The poet tenderly beckons his wife to the window where she too can enjoy the pleasant breeze. Upto this point nature is calm beautiful and soothing. But, from here on, the poet discerns the underlying grating sound which he describes at some length till the end of the first stanza. The poet draws his wife's attention to the moonlit beach and to the point where the waves lap the shore, the sound of the pebbles as they are dragged along the beach by the receding waves. These pebbles are once again pushed up the sloping beach as the tide returns. Thus there is constant sound and motion that begins and ceases and begins again. The trembling rhythm seems to symbolize some kind of unending sorrow.

Lines 14-20 carry forward this notion of eternity by harking back to the time of Sophocles. This 'grating roar' was probably also heard by Sophocles long ago on the shores of the Aegean sea and it was this, that perhaps induced in his mind the sense of the miseries in human life which are reflected in his great tragedies. Just as the sound of the ebb and flow of the waves was able to evoke the feeling of human misery in Sophocles' mind, so also it evokes similar thoughts in the mind of Arnold and his wife who stand much further north, separated from him by time and space.

From this reference to Sophocles and the past, Arnold returns to the immediate present ruminating philosophically on the spiritual decline that has besieged human beings. But this thinking is done in the shape of images. Arnold explains that at one time religious faith supported and helped mankind and was at its strongest. This religious faith was like a beautiful garment that engirdled the earth. In short, this faith was universal. But now

BEGC-110_3rd Proof.indb 189 6/21/2021 11:41:05 AM

the poet can only hear the receding tide which draws back with a sad sound to the music of the night winds leaving the beach exposed and uncovered. Similarly, the poet is aware of the fact that people have lost faith in religion which has withdrawn from everywhere like the outgoing tide. This spiritual decline has left human beings vulnerable and exposed to the sorrows of life.

What can one do in such a situation? The poet appeals to Lucy once more. He believes that if they love each other truly, they will be able to discover some value in life. Loss of religious faith has made it impossible to believe that the universe is to some extent atuned to human needs. He says that the world they can see before them is beautiful like a dream. But inspite of its varied beauty it cannot offer either joy, love, hope or certainty to anyone. People can have no peace and continue to suffer pain.

From the sea image, the poet moves in the final lines to a startling new image---that of a field with a battle raging in the dark where it is not clear who is the friend or who the enemy or why they are fighting at all.

Style

The melancholy tone of the poem arises from a feeling of deep despair. The stanzas are of different length and the lines move with a steady and poised rhythm

'The sea is calm tonight
The tide is full ...'

The ebbing and flowing of the waves and the consequent 'grating roar' is evoked vividly in 'draw back' 'fling' 'begin, and cease, and then again begin'. J.D. Jump calls this 'a combination of metrical and syntactical means' a combination of sound and sense to present this wonderfully rich image. The lines

'But now I only hear
Its melancholy, long, withdrawing roar
Retreating, to the breath
Of the night-wind ....'.

are as Miriam Allott puts it 'Probably the most musically expressive passage in all of Arnold's poetry and a valid poetic equivalent for his feelings of loss, exposure and dismay'. (*Matthew Arnold : Selected Poems and Prose,* pp 278-9).

The image of the sea is present throughout the poem. But in the last 3 lines we are taken to a 'darkling plain'. The sea is calm at the outset. Slowly a 'grating roar' is discernible, an ebb and flow that turns the poet's thoughts to meditate on the loss of faith with which humanity was now beset. This loss of religious faith is depicted by the image of the receding tide with its melancholy, long, withdrawing roar'. What is the result of this loss of faith? Without religious faith to invest life with some meaning and sense of value, the world is like an anarchic battlefield in the dark where people ignorant of their friends and foes are engaged in a hideous clash.

As we know, poems with philosophic meditations are usually not very lyrical or appealing. However, 'Dover Beach' is both. How has Arnold succeeded

BEGC-110_3rd Proof.indb 190 6/21/2021 11:41:05 AM

in creating this rich lyric? He has worked in images which have given a concrete aspect to his thought. These images then evoke delightful feelings in the reader who responds to the sheer visual power of the metaphors used. In all three poems we have noticed a melancholy strain. Arnold's poetry appeals primarily to the intellect but it also appeals to our senses through the use of powerful images, chief of which, as we have seen, is the sea.

Check Your Progress 3

In your own words, write down the theme of 'Dover Beach' in the space given below. (about 100 words)

.....

.....

.....

.....

.....

(Check your answer with that given at the end of this Unit.)

1.6 LET US SUM UP

In this unit, we have discussed

- the life and works of Matthew Arnold;
- three elegiac poems by Arnold which establish him as the melancholy poet who expressed the spirit of his times;
- the poetic technique of Arnold.

1.7 ANSWERS TO CHECK YOUR PROGRESS

Check Your Progress 1

i) For a reference to context question you need to bear in mind the following points:

   a) start by saying which poem the lines are taken from and who is the author—one may briefly mention something about the specific characteristics of that poet's techniques.

   b) explain the background of the poem and how these lines fit into its overall context:

   c) paraphrase the lines and

   d) in conclusion make some remarks about the style of the poem.

Check Your Progress 2

i) A central idea is NOT a summary of the poem. We need to give the essence or main idea contained in the poem. In this poem it is the universal isolation of the human beings.

Check Your Progress 3

The theme of 'Dover Beach' seems to be the poet's concern with humanity having lost its religious faith and the subsequent vulnerability of human beings to the pain and sufferings of life. This, according to the poet, can only be regained by love for one another.

BEGC-110_3rd Proof.indb 191 6/21/2021 11:41:06 AM